

DECLUTTER YOUR HOME, CALM YOUR LIFE

*A Room-by-Room Guide to Simple Living,
Organized Spaces, and Stress-Free Daily Routines*

ALEX LEE

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PHASE I

THE FOUNDATION
& MINDSET

INTRODUCTION

The Journey to a Calmer Life



Let me start by saying you are not alone, and you're not failing at being an adult.

If you're reading this book, chances are you've had some of the following experiences in your daily routine. You enter your home and, looking around your entryway, you see shoes in disarray around the doorway, children's jackets on the floor, a pile of mail awaiting attention. The garage can't house the car because you have sports equipment, camping gear, and even a baby stroller that belonged to your now five-year-old. Your kitchen counter is full of appliances—an air fryer, a coffee maker, a toaster, a pressure cooker, a kettle—and another stack of mail. In every room in your house, there appears to be just too much of something. (I'll call it “stuff” for now.) You reflect on your friends' homes. Everyone else seems to be more organized and less cluttered. Maybe you tried to get organized in the past. You bought bins, labels, and baskets, but went back to where you started six months later.

Well, this is what you should know: the problem is not you. It has never been about you.

Clutter is not a flaw in your character; you're not lazy or messy. It's the result of busy professionals, parents raising kids, and people trying to do too much with too little time. Beyond that, most

of us live in a culture where we're pushed to want more, and the overwhelm comes from managing endless amounts of stuff.

Most of us have accumulated too much, but the stuff isn't the core problem. Many items at home have a story. They could be tied to guilt, obligation, hope, memory, or identity. Do you feel obliged to keep gifts though you don't need or want them? Is it because someone special gave you that shirt or sweater? Do you have a special set of dinnerware that you might use someday but haven't in the last three years? Do you keep baby clothes for the memories?

This is why you can't just toss the stuff in the trash. You need to tell the stories behind the objects. You need to acknowledge what they represent, what gave rise to them, before you can be ready to part ways. This is what human beings do.

Scientifically, clutter has a measurable effect on your mind and body; the visual chaos of having too much stuff increases your cortisol—a stress hormone. As you walk in through your entryway, look at your garage, or sit in your kitchen, your brain is processing (or trying to process) the visual stimulus. And because there's too much information, too much stimulus, your brain can't fully relax and is in a constant state of low-level alertness.

Over time, this stress builds up and affects your mood, sleep, patience, and ability to focus on your work and health. Primarily, this is more about wellness and having peace of mind and improved quality of life. Secondly, you get the benefits of a prettier home. Decluttering is more than just organizing; it is a pathway to the practice of wellness.

Let me make you a promise. If you take the step to work through the guidance of this book with intention and consistency, there will be meaningful change. You will still be who you are, but you will utilize more effective systems.

A simplified home can provide many benefits:

- **Mental clarity and reduced stress:** An uncluttered environment will support your brain. You'll be able to think more clearly, make decisions, and feel less overwhelmed. If you feel like you've been living in a foggy, scattered state, it may be due to the environment. This will change.
- **Better sleep quality:** When your bedroom becomes a peaceful sanctuary, you'll fall asleep more easily, sleep more deeply, and be more rested. This will only happen when your bedroom becomes a sanctuary, not a storage unit.
- **More time and energy:** Your time will not be spent managing the excess. How many times have you lost your keys or phone at home? Worse, how long did it take to find them, and what was the time spent over the course of the year? There are things that matter, and those deserve your time rather than constantly searching for your keys.
- **You will build stronger relationships:** You'll have energy to be present. Your brain won't be distracted by the clutter during conversations. You can have guests over because you don't need to tidy up before they arrive. There will be no need to stress before entertaining.

Before getting there, you need to change your mindset about what decluttering really is. The truth is, decluttering is not really about stuff. It is understanding our relationship with the stuff.

Most think of this as an organizational problem. Ironically, they think they need to develop a better approach and buy more stuff like storage solutions, a bigger closet, or bins and containers. They watch videos, try different methods, and nothing works because they're treating the symptoms and not addressing the root cause.

So, what is the problem? You don't need to organize better; **you need to own less**. Once you arrive at that conclusion, everything

becomes easier. You don't need an organizational system to organize twelve pans; you need to get rid of seven and keep the five that you use. You don't need an elaborate closet solution; you need to get rid of the clothes you haven't worn in two years. Some don't fit, some are no longer in fashion, and some you don't like. It really is that simple.

This is radically different from what the organizing industry wants to sell to you. They make money when you buy products to organize your stuff. They don't make money when you reduce your stuff to the point that you don't need their products. But I'm not selling you organizing systems. I'm offering you freedom.

Throughout this book, I'm going to give you one question that cuts through all the guilt, all the "what ifs," and all the mental gymnastics we use to justify keeping things. Here it is: *Does this item serve my life as it is right now?* I'm not referring to the life you wish you had or that person you hope to become someday. Your life. Right now. Today. The life you're living with, the person you actually are.

This question will serve as your true North Star. If you pick up an object and you feel a sense of paralysis, then ask yourself the following question: Does this item serve my life right now? A variety of thoughts might permeate your mind: "I might need this," "I spent good money on this," or "Auntie gave me this." These thoughts simply cloud your judgment.

If the answer is no, it doesn't matter what it costs, who gave it to you, or how long you've been keeping it. If it doesn't serve your actual life, it's clutter, and clutter has a cost. It costs you space, energy, time, and peace.

Now, I know what some of you are thinking. It's something like, "I don't want a minimalist house with three articles of clothes and a few pieces of furniture." This is not that; it's not deprivation or perfection. It's creating a home that is functional, that supports

your life and allows you to breathe. For some, that may mean a very minimalist space. For others, it might mean a cozy, lived-in home full of beloved books and meaningful art that just happens to be free of excess. The goal is freedom, not emptiness.

Our process has four phases, and we'll move through these phases in order because the order is important. Currently, we're in **Phase I**, which focuses on our attitudes and beliefs, exploring why we hold on to things and giving ourselves permission to release them. This is a crucial first step. If it's bypassed, the emotional toll of decluttering could cause you to give up and cause the clutter to reaccumulate in a year.

Phase II is about building the decision systems and a workable roadmap. This will help to avoid decision-making fatigue and keep your efforts on track. You're going to learn frameworks that make it easier to make decisions consistently, with a clear order for addressing the cluttered spaces. This is the infrastructure that separates those who will succeed from those who throw up their hands halfway through the process.

Phase III is where we'll go through your home, room by room, and apply our decision systems. This is the part where we really start decluttering. It's the longest and most demanding phase; however, this is where we see the results. We start with easier areas to build quick wins, confidence, and momentum. We'll save the hardest spaces for when you're prepared and capable of the challenge.

Phase IV is about maintaining what was built through the creation of routines to keep the house in order long after the book has finished. We'll look at ways to prevent the return of clutter and broaden these concepts in your life.

Before we dive into any of that, we need to talk about why this matters to you specifically. If you don't connect with why you want this change, you will lose steam or give up when things get hard.

There will be times when you're there holding your grandmother's china that you have never used and will probably never use and feeling like the worst person in the world for even considering donating it. There will be moments when you're exhausted and just want to shove everything in a closet and be done. There will be moments when you question what you're doing and whether it's worth it.

Your "why" is your anchor, and it's what will help you get past those moments.

Maybe your "why" is wanting to stop getting angry with your kids over the mess. You want to change this situation, but the current environment makes this impossible.

Maybe it's the hesitation of hosting because you're embarrassed about how your home looks. You want to be able to be a spontaneous host without going through panic cleaning.

Maybe it's about the endless cycle of cleaning and organizing that never seems to work. You restore order on the weekend, and by mid-week, the chaos has returned.

It could be something different, like retirement, divorce, or becoming an empty nester. A life shift can make it clear that time is too precious to be managing stuff. Whether it's a new home or a new chapter, the impact of the decision not to carry clutter with you can be immense.

Whatever your "why" is, it matters. It's what will help you power through this process. So, pause now to get a clear view of this, not a general reason like "to be more organized" but a specific, tangible reason.

Close your eyes and picture your decluttered home six months from now. What does it look like? More importantly, what does it feel like? How do you feel when you walk through the door? What becomes possible that is not possible now? What changes would there be in your daily life?

Get specific. Paint the picture. Feel the feelings. This vision is your North Star.

This is not about having a perfect home; you're not out to impress but to create a home that works for you and makes your life easier.

This is not to lay blame on yourself or judgment on others. You are not a bad person for having clutter. The people who contributed to it—the gift-givers, family who passed down stuff—are not bad either. We're all doing our best.

This is not about speed. This is not a weekend project. Real, lasting decluttering takes time and will go on for months. But this is okay as long as you are moving towards your true North Star. You're doing this for yourself to create more space for what brings you joy, comfort, and meaning.

This is about reclaiming your home, your time, and your energy. You want to create that space, both physical and mental, for what matters. This is about setting boundaries with the stuff, the commitments, and the pressure to acquire more.

The journey ahead will ask you to be honest about what you use versus what you think you should keep. It will ask you to feel some uncomfortable emotions: grief for money spent, guilt about gifts, disappointment about aspirational items. It will ask you to make many decisions, which is genuinely exhausting.

I promise that in return, at the end, on the other side of this process, you're going to walk into your home and feel peace instead of stress. You're going to find what you need without frantic searching. You're going to have mornings that don't start with chaos and evenings that don't end in exhaustion. You're going to have mental bandwidth for what matters, such as creativity, connection, rest, and joy.

That's worth some temporary discomfort, isn't it?

Take a deep breath. Look around at the space you're in right now. See it for what it is. It is not a judgment on you but simply

the current state of things. Your home is currently cluttered. That's a description, not an indictment. And know that this state is not permanent. You have the power to change it, and here is how we're going to do it.

We're going to do this together by giving you the frameworks, the systems, the strategies, and the permission. You're going to bring your commitment, your honesty, and your willingness to do the work. Together, we're going to transform your home and, in the process, transform your daily life.

Let's begin.

CHAPTER 1

The Decluttering Mindset - The Power of Permission



Have you ever stood at the door of your closet holding a sweater that you haven't worn for as long as you can remember? You're debating whether you should keep it or donate it. I refer to this as "decluttering paralysis." This is the feeling of being in a state of limbo. You know deep inside that you need to let this item go, but somehow you're unwilling or unable to do it emotionally.

Most conclude that this stumbling block is about being indecisive. They might think they are "bad decision makers" or "too sentimental." This is not the case; it's not about your character. Your brain has natural barriers that are stopping you from deciding, and these must be addressed first.

This truth changes everything and allows you to see from a different point of view. Often, clutter is the accumulation of past promises. You believe that these items would help you become a different person. The blender was going to make you consume more vegetables. The running shoes would make you a runner. Buying

the guitar was going to make you musical and appreciate music. Did it happen?

When the intended transformations don't happen, these items are assumed to be evidence of failure. This "stuff" serves as a reminder of what you thought you wanted to be. With that, it becomes even harder to release these items because if you do, it's like admitting failure.

But your identity is not driven by the purchase of an item. Buying something is not the same as *being* something. The items didn't fail you, and you didn't fail either. Our consumer culture is trying to sell us stuff that's supposed to make us happier. If you buy these running shoes, you'll become a runner. If you buy these containers, you'll be organized. Material possessions do not change us; our actions initiate change. Habits and choices change us, but purchasing things does not change us.

Once you see the world of clutter through this perspective, through this lens, then something shifts. These are not items you might use someday. These are anchors that represent unfulfilled expectations. These items can be released because they never had the power to deliver the promise you instilled in them. If you're not a runner, those shoes were not going to make you a runner.

Let's talk through the specific emotional barriers that keep you stuck because once you identify them, you can move on.

The Scarcity Mindset

There's a voice in your head that's saying, "What if I need this someday?" You think letting go means you won't have it when you need it. Later, you might kick yourself for having thrown away or donated it. Perhaps you grew up in a time when money was tight, and you kept everything just in case it was needed someday. In the past, at least for some, there was less stuff and enough space for the

stuff; clutter was not an issue. Some may have learned that resources need to be hoarded to ensure survival. Now, though circumstances may have changed, those habits and practices are ingrained, and the neural pathway has been hardwired for this mindset.

The scarcity mindset shows up as statements like “It still works!” But it is never used. “I might need this.” But you never needed it in years. “I paid good money for this.” But the money is a sunk cost; it’s gone whether you keep it or not. (Of course, some items could be resold for money. That will be discussed later.)

The reality is that, most often, the “someday” never arrives. On the off chance you need an item after it’s donated or trashed, you could almost borrow, rent, or even buy it at a lower cost than storing it for years.

Think about storage costs. This extends beyond the dollar value. If it takes up space in the garage, maybe there’s no room for your car. Even an unused space is worthwhile because it gives you some breathing room. Also, think about the mental cost. If you keep something you might need someday, it occupies space in your brain. You must remember where you put it on the off chance you might need it. It’s not one item you must remember; it’s the multitude of items you’re keeping. This creates cognitive overload and is exhausting.

The antidote to scarcity is abundance. We’re not pretending you have unlimited resources, but we live in a world where things are generally available when you need them. You can borrow a whisk if yours breaks. You can borrow a ladder for the off chance you might need it. You can rent a carpet cleaner if you need it. You can solve problems as they arise.

Here’s an experiment. What’s the worst thing that would happen if you donated an item you later needed? You could borrow it, maybe buy it again. Maybe you could accomplish the task differently without that item.

When you follow the scarcity mindset to its conclusion, you'll discover you may be occasionally inconvenienced. This inconvenience can be solved and is a small price to pay for a less cluttered home.

Objects as Memory Proxies

This is perhaps the most emotional barrier. You keep your grandmother's chinaware because it was handed down or gifted to you. You don't like it, it's not your style, you would not use it. However, if you donate it, it's like letting go of your grandmother. You keep your children's baby clothes because the onesies are so cute; they represent a precious time that has passed.

These objects feel like they are holding or containing memories. You feel that if you lose the object, you lose the memory. Here's the gentle truth: the memory is inside of you, not contained in those objects.

Your grandmother is not inside the chinaware. The love you have for her, your memories of her, and the impact she had on your life are all contained in you. The memories are in your values and stories and within your DNA. We see this in the phrases you use and the way you cook certain foods. A physical object can trigger a memory, but it's not the memory itself. If the chinaware is stored in the highest cabinet within a box, it will never serve as a memory trigger.

You will still remember your grandmother if you donate the chinaware. The baby years will still be there if you keep five items rather than forty. The past remains within you, while the objects are just objects.

Sometimes, it makes sense to keep half a dozen items you like and want to display. These items can serve as a memory trigger if they are honored, cherished, and visible. If you keep forty items, it's not honoring them; it's storing them.

Let's talk a bit about curating. Did you know museums have vast storage facilities filled with items that most visitors will never see? If they displayed everything, it would overwhelm people. Instead, curators thoughtfully select the most representative and impactful pieces.

You can do the same with your sentimental items: you can be the curator. Choose those that are the most meaningful, most useful, and let the rest go. It's not dishonoring the people or memories; it's the opposite. Now, you'll be giving the more significant items the space and attention they deserve.

Take a bold step with your keepsakes and set a quantifiable limit. This is a personal decision. It could be one storage bin, one box, one shelf. *You* must define it, but make it concrete. This forces curation. You choose the most meaningful rather than keeping everything out of guilt, fear, or indecisiveness.

If you have unlimited space, then everything is "meaningful," and you can sidestep making choices. However, when you must choose, you distinguish between what is precious and what is just old. This is a valuable process as you internalize what truly matters to you.

The "Good Host" Pressure

Do you have extra sheets ready for guests? How often do you really have guests who stay over? Do you have a drawer or box of toiletries in case your guest forgets to bring their toothbrush or toothpaste? Do you have place settings for fifteen people when you normally serve five?

This is sometimes referred to as "good host" pressure. Some people, through their upbringing, have been conditioned to prioritize guest comfort over themselves. Our homes have been transformed into hotels for guests who rarely come.

Here's a bit of a reality check: hospitality is about making guests feel welcome, comfortable, and cared for. Your guests don't need a memory foam mattress topper or four types of breakfast cereals. They would much prefer that you are present, relaxed, and happy to see them rather than exhausted from maintaining a museum of "just in case" items.

Reminisce about the best hosting experience you've had. Why was it special? Do you remember the sheets or an extra toothbrush? Or is it perhaps staying up and talking, laughing, feeling wanted? Good hosting is establishing a presence with your guests; it's not about the stuff.

If a guest needs to sleep on an air mattress, it will be fine. They will survive. They might need an extra sheet, but not four. If they forget their toothbrush, lend them the spare.

Adjust your hospitality items to reflect reality. If you expect guests four times per year, then plan for that. Don't prepare for every contingency or scenario. That just creates anxiety.

The Preparedness Paradox

This barrier says, "I need to keep these items because I might need them in an emergency." The irony is that, in an emergency, you could not possibly find the items you need among the multitude of items you own. Keeping too many items makes us less prepared.

Being prepared is not about quantity; it's about having a reasonable amount of the essential items in logical and accessible places. It's not about having flashlights scattered throughout the house, but having two flashlights in a designated location where anyone can access them as needed. It's not about having forty cans of soup. It's about having a week of nonperishable food you can rotate through.

This paradox shows up in first aid supplies stored in different closets and drawers throughout the house. During an emergency, you find yourself moving from closet to drawer looking for pills, only to find out they've expired. Alternatively, you go to access the batteries and find that they no longer work.

In your preparations, organize the supplies intentionally and with purpose. One well-organized and fully stocked emergency kit is more useful than an eclectic mix of emergency supplies dispersed around the house. Prioritize quality and accessibility over quantity.

The Aspirational Item Framework

Let's shift focus to aspirational items, as this is the category that derails many. Aspirational items are those you keep for the "future you." This could be you, "the chef," the version of yourself who cooks fancy meals with the cookware you acquired but never used. This could be you, "the camper," the version of you who's collected camping gear but never gone camping. This could be you, "the athlete," the version of yourself with all the equipment to play a sport that never quite became part of your routine.

These items do not serve a purpose; they are actively harming you. When you see these items, they remind you of a gap between your current self and your visions of what you want to be. They're whispering, "You're not there yet" or "You're not good enough."

So, here's the framework. Have you taken steps toward these goals or aspirations in the past six months? If the answer is "No," then these items aren't triggers for change. These items are aspirational.

If you want to be a painter, you need to attend class or set aside time to paint. The painting materials you bought are not making you a painter. If you want to be a hiker, you should go on a hike with others or by yourself. The hiking boots do not make you a hiker.

The counterintuitive truth is that when you let go of aspirational items, oftentimes it frees you up to pursue your real passions. You'll no longer be weighed down by guilt or aspiring to be someone you're not. Instead, you can be honest about who you want to be. Sometimes you might arrive at the conclusion that you didn't want that thing at all; you just thought you wanted it.

So, releasing those aspirational items will give you permission to be who you really are. You'll be able to live the life you want to live. The real you deserves a supporting home, not a home cluttered with the debris of your imagined lives.

Before moving forward, notice that we haven't touched a single item yet. The work thus far has been internal work, shifting your mindset and reframing. This work is equally as important as the act of physical decluttering and arguably more so. The reason is that if you try to declutter without addressing emotional barriers, you'll either give up or end up reaccumulating more the following year.

Don't worry—the physical work is coming. We'll use decision frameworks that eliminate decision fatigue. We'll create systems to keep from backsliding. Our approach will have us go through each room systematically.

Your current focus should be to reflect on these ideas. You'll want to notice which emotional barriers resonate with you. Is it the scarcity mindset? The memory proxy trap? Good host pressure? The preparedness paradox? You could have more than one barrier. Observe how you feel about each of these barriers.

Permission to Let Go

Let's move on to the antidote of permission. We live in a society where we're conditioned to acquire, not to release. We're constantly encouraged to buy, collect, and accumulate. When we have too much, we go rent storage space, we upsize to a bigger house, and we

have guilt when we downsize. So, I give you permission to release without reservation.

- **You have permission to let go of gifts you don't want.** You've received gifts to make you happy, whether for birthdays, holidays, or weddings. If you're not happy when you see the gift, that's a problem. The gift has already served its purpose; it was given in love. You don't need the object to remain in the house forever; the love was still real.

When you receive a gift, it's yours, as the ownership has been transferred. Once you own it, you can decide its fate. If you keep something out of obligation, it doesn't honor the giver; it clutters your home and weighs on your conscience. There is someone out there who would like it and has a use for it. That would honor the spirit of the gift.

- **You have permission to let go of items that represent past stages of your life.** You're free to transform into the version of yourself that you want to be. Do you have the same hobbies now as you did twenty years ago? Do you have new interests now? Why hold on to the old when your style is evolving? The items that served you in the past don't need to serve you now.

Your scrapbook supplies—are you using them? If not, give them away to someone who is engaged in this passion. How about your formal clothes? Are you now working remotely or semi-retired? Consider paring down the formal wardrobe as a compromise. It's not wasteful but honest. It frees up space for now and makes space for what might be coming.

You're allowed to change. You're allowed to outgrow hobbies, evolve your style, and move on from old dreams.

- **You have permission to let go of regretful purchases.**

The sunk cost fallacy is the belief that if you spent money on something, you must keep it to justify the expense. The money is already spent; it's a sunk cost. Keeping the purchase doesn't give you the money back. It's just a memory of the money you spent on the object.

When you look at your exercise bike or your treadmill, if you don't use it, you feel bad. It will punish you if the item is not being used. Let it go. Release yourself from the punishment and reclaim your space and peace.

As you begin to discard, donate, or sell items, patterns will begin to emerge. You'll observe that you've made impulse buys and how you fell victim to marketing gimmicks. With this insight, you can be better prepared for the future.

- **You have permission to let go of things you're keeping out of guilt.** We've accumulated family heirlooms, wedding gifts, items from deceased relatives. Guilt is a common but not good enough reason to sacrifice your living space and peace of mind.

If you've inherited items from someone who passed on, you should focus on your relationship with that person—your grief, your love. Nothing is taken away by letting go of their belongings you now harbor. Your house is not a museum for their items. You can keep a few keepsakes you genuinely like and want to showcase, but the rest can be donated to those who want them.

Let's recap. You can create a home that serves your purposes right now. This includes letting go of anything that doesn't serve you now. This is regardless of the cost of the items, who gave you the items, how long you've kept them, or what you thought you'd

become. You have permission and the right to define your own “enough.” You can change your mind and disappoint others.

After all, this is your life, and this is your home. You decide what stays and what goes. It is not selfish, wasteful, or disrespectful. It is a liberation. This is the first step of the journey. You’re ready to start.

PHASE II

BUILDING THE ACTION PLAN

CHAPTER 2

Building the Foundation - Systems That Stick



We've walked through shifting our mindset and giving ourselves permission to let go of items we don't want. Now, we'll build on the external systems that will carry you through this project. Your success in decluttering usually has nothing to do with your will or your desire and everything to do with preparation. You are here because you want to declutter.

You typically will not fail because you lack motivation or are undisciplined. Failure is more commonly caused by decision fatigue without a clear roadmap. If you start with the hardest space, you'll be overwhelmed because you don't have the system to deal with the items you want to discard. You need a good system, not the brute force of trying harder.

This chapter is about forming a decluttering infrastructure. We're going to create frameworks, gather tools, and design the sequence that will make the actual work easier and as smooth as possible. This phase might not feel like "real work," as you're not moving things into donation boxes or trash, but this is where the magic happens.

This will separate people who finish from those who give up halfway through with boxes of donations and “stuff” sitting in their garage in six months.

This chapter is about slowing down rather than jumping into declutter haphazardly. You might be thinking, “Just tell me what to do, and I’ll do it!” or “Let’s just get started, right now!” This is all understandable. But if you skip this preparation step, then most likely you will hit the wall, and the process will fail. You’ll be standing in the middle of your living room with piles of stuff, paralyzed with decisions and at a loss. After that, all the stuff will find its way into storage boxes, and you’ll conclude that decluttering does not work for you.

It’s better to build the foundation and get to the end. This is my recommended approach.

Step 1: Know Your Starting Point

Before starting, you need to assess what you’re working with. This is a data-driven assessment, not a judgment. You can’t celebrate progress if you don’t know your starting point. Neither can you implement an effective strategy if you don’t understand the scope of the problem.

This is what you need to do in your whole home assessment. You should budget about forty-five minutes of uninterrupted time. You’ll want to go old school with a notebook. I recommend an actual notebook because on the phone, tablet, or computer, you might get distracted. If you genuinely prefer an app to take notes, that’s up to you. Take a physical walkthrough of each room in your house, including the garage, closets, and the attic.

For each space, you’re going to record four pieces of information.

First, what’s the current function of this space? This means the *actual* function of space rather than the *intended* function.

The spare bedroom might be intended as a guest room, but it is currently serving the function of a storage unit with a bed buried in boxes. Write this down and be honest. The dining room might be intended for family meals, but it's currently serving as a multi-purpose horizontal filing system for mail, homework, and random shopping bags. Write this down and acknowledge this reality. The garage was intended as a roof over your car, but the car is in the driveway because the garage is too full of stuff to fit a car. Write this down without judgment and be honest. You can't solve a problem if you don't acknowledge it.

Second, what are the specific problem areas? You need to write down the problem areas specifically. Don't use vague terms like "messy." Does the kitchen counter accumulate non-food or non-kitchen-related items? Does your linen closet have towels and linens overflowing so much that you must shove things back to make them fit? Is your bathroom drawer full of half-empty bottles and expired medications? Is the bedroom full of clothes on the floor where you drop things off each day? Be specific; name the problems. Vague problems are not helpful and create anxiety.

Third, how does this space make you feel? This is important, yet it might feel strange to document your feelings about a room. Does the entryway give you stress the moment you walk in? Does your bedroom make you feel more anxious than restful? Does your kitchen overwhelm you before you start cooking? Is your living room an embarrassment when someone stops by unexpectedly? Does your garage make you feel so overwhelmed that you don't want to enter it? Your emotional responses are an important barometer; they indicate which spaces are actively harming you and which are working well enough. This step helps you prioritize the spaces that urgently need attention.

Fourth, what do you wish this space could do for you? What is your dream for this space or that room? Do you want the kitchen

to be a place where cooking feels easy instead of a chore you dread? Perhaps you want your bedroom to be a place that helps you sleep better rather than a place of visual chaos. Maybe you want your entryway to be a place for your keys, coats, and shoes rather than a place of disarray. Maybe you want your garage to fit the car. Write down the vision, the dream, even if it appears impossible now—especially if it appears impossible now.

This is a multipurpose assessment. It provides a baseline to track progress. In three months, you'll be able to reference these notes and see concrete evidence about how far you've come. If you get discouraged in the process when you feel like nothing is changing, you can see proof that it is. This highlights places causing the most stress and might influence the sequence of actions. Some people need to tackle the most stressful place first to gain some relief. Others might focus on a smaller space, building success before moving on. This forces you to articulate what you want. The goal isn't really "I want to declutter." It's "I want to cook a meal without having to clean my kitchen first." It gives us permission to acknowledge that the current state does not work, without getting upset about it.

Post-assessment, you'll have a clear map of your starting point. Keep this. Don't lose it or throw it away. You'll want to reflect in three months and marvel at the transformation. Some have told me they get emotional when they look back because they have forgotten how bad things were at the beginning of their journey. This documentation is powerful.

Step 2: Set Your "Why"

We brought this up in the **Introduction**, but now we're going to get specific and concrete. A wish is not a goal. For example, "I want to be more organized" is a wish, not a goal. It won't sustain you when you're tired and overwhelmed and standing in your garage

surrounded by twenty years of accumulated stuff, trying to decide what to do with your ex-husband's golf clubs that he left behind in 2012.

You need something that's visceral and concrete, something you can lean on to pull you through the moments when the going gets tough. And make no mistake—there will be hard moments. There will be moments when you want to quit. There will be moments when it feels like it's too much. Your “why” is your anchor in those moments.

So, what does a good “why” look like? It's specific, it's tied to your actual daily life, and it has emotional weight. Let me give you some examples.

“Find my keys every morning without searching” is a good “why.” It's specific, and you can picture exactly what this means. You can visualize walking through your home searching for those keys while your kids are late for school, you're trying to get to work, and the stress levels are rising. In contrast, you can see yourself quickly picking up your keys and everyone leaving the house in a peaceful manner. There's emotional weight to this vision. It's starting the day in control and feeling capable versus full of stress.

“Cook dinner without clearing clutter first” is another example of a good “why.” Instead of spending time moving mail and random items and wiping things down before you can begin the cooking process, you want to be able to walk into a functional kitchen and begin.

“Have friends over without panic-cleaning for two days” is another good why. This is all about connecting and building connections without the state of your home isolating you from these relationships. You don't want to say or think “I'd love to have you over, but can we make it next weekend so I have time to clean?” but rather “Come over tonight! I'd love to see you.”

“Get the kids out the door without morning chaos” is a good “why” for those with kids. It’s about wanting to start the morning off without conflict. You don’t want to be looking for homework, a permission slip, or some other missing item. It’s about sidestepping that morning stress.

What do all of these have in common? They’re about life, not about the stuff. They’re about the moments that matter, the experiences you want to change, and relationships. They’re about who you want to be and how you want to feel and not about the appearance of the home.

Your “why” might be different. Maybe you work at home and don’t want to be distracted by the mess. Perhaps you’re thinking about moving and don’t want to transport the clutter. Maybe you want to prove that you can do this. It doesn’t matter.

Write down your “why” physically, not just mentally, so that you can see it regularly. You can write a sticky note on your computer monitor or set a reminder on your phone. When you start, this will provide some self-motivation.

In this process, eventually you will hit the wall. You might be looking at sentimental items, paralyzed with decisions. After three hours, the room you chose to declutter looks the same or maybe even worse than when you began. That’s the time to review your “why.” Reconnecting with where you’re coming from will give you the strength to keep going.

Some might try to abbreviate this step by not thinking through the “why,” holding it in your head and not writing it down. Writing it down will be your true North Star in this journey.

Step 3: The Momentum Roadmap

One thing people get catastrophically wrong is that they start with the biggest problem first. The belief is that if they take out the biggest

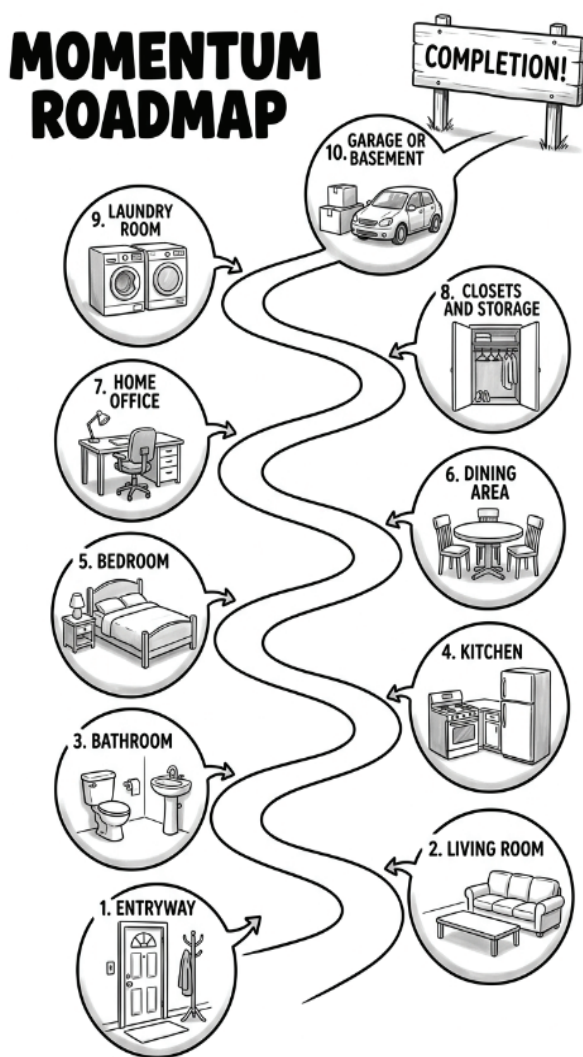
problem, everything else will be easy. Specifically, they dive into the garage, basement, or the spare room and tackle it first. Typically, these are the storage havens; the stuff there has been accumulating for decades. These are the toughest areas. If you start with these, most likely you'll be overwhelmed and quit. Shortly after you get started, you'll conclude that decluttering is too hard and quit. But you're not bad at decluttering. You simply started in the wrong place.

The secret is sequencing. Decluttering is strategic sequencing. It's choosing the order in which you tackle spaces and building momentum as you go, rather than killing it. It's not about avoiding the problem. You need to build up the skills and confidence to tackle the hard stuff when you get there.

An analogy might be going to the gym and working out. You don't go in on day one and start lifting the maximum weight. Similarly, you don't suddenly start running ten miles on the first day. This thinking and approach will be a disaster. First, you build strength; then, you develop proper form and gradually take up bigger challenges. This is the same with decluttering.

Start with spaces that give you quick, visible wins without destroying you. Try to alternate between hard and easy projects to prevent burnout. You want to save the overwhelming spaces for when your confidence and decision-making skills are at their peak.

Below is a recommended sequence. It can be adjusted, but this will generally be a good flow to follow: (note: this is a suggested order of priority, not the order the chapters appear in the book—jump to whichever chapter matches your next room):



Start with the entryway (1–2 hours). This should be a good first project because the space is small. Typically, there aren't sentimental items there, and it's highly visible. Usually, there's high traffic flow through the entryway, so as you and others walk through it, there will be evidence of your progress. The entryway is high impact because it is the transition between the inside and

the outside. A clear entryway will signal that you are home and safe, while a cluttered entryway assaults with chaos.

Next, tackle the living room (3–4 hours). The living room is a medium project. It has more stuff than the entryway—maybe some sentimental items like photos or books—but it’s still manageable. This is likely the largest public space, and when done, you’ll feel a shift when you walk into the room. It’s where you spend a lot of time, so the benefits are compounded. When visitors notice it, this provides external validation and reinforces your motivation.

After a major project like the living room, give yourself a quick win with a bathroom (2–3 hours). The bathroom is a lighter project and can give you a quick win and a mental break. Though bathrooms are small, there’s usually a lot of trash, such as expired medications, products bought but never used, or old cosmetics. You can complete this in one session without exhausting yourself. A clean and clear bathroom will make you feel capable.

Now you’re ready for the kitchen (8–12 hours, probably split across multiple sessions). This is a major project and probably the single biggest project besides the basement and maybe the garage. You’ve built some momentum and confidence and know that the decision framework works. You have the mental muscle to make decisions without second-guessing yourself. The kitchen is used multiple times a day, so when it’s decluttered, the work will be well worth the reward. A functional kitchen is profound. It affects what you eat, the time you spend preparing food, and the stress you feel around meals and cooking.

From here, move through bedrooms (4–6 hours per bedroom). Your bedroom is critical because it affects your sleep, and sleep affects everyone. Declutter your bedroom first to reap the benefits and then approach the other bedrooms. Kids’ rooms might take 3–5 hours each, depending on your kids’ age and the level of toy clutter.

The dining area comes next (2–3 hours). This can be a quick win area. The dining area doesn't typically have massive amounts of stuff; it just has the wrong stuff. For example, the dining room table might be a horizontal filing cabinet of mail, homework, and half-done projects. Attacking and reclaiming this space for the intended purpose will be significant, allowing for those family meals.

If you have a dedicated home office or workspace, tackle it next (2–3 hours). This step is optional—not every household has one, and that is perfectly fine. For those who do, this space is often not a massive project but usually has the wrong stuff in the wrong places. The desk has become a horizontal filing cabinet, cables have multiplied, and supplies have accumulated well beyond what any one person needs. Reclaiming this space for focused, productive work pays dividends every single day, especially for those working from home.

Then tackle closets and storage spaces (4–8 hours total, depending on how many you have). By now, you have the decision-making skills to attack the clothes, potentially a lot of clothes! But you're ready and well-equipped.

The laundry room is another relatively quick win (2–3 hours). This is a small space, and putting it into a functional, organized state makes the space work better.

And finally, only after you've built your skills and confidence through all those other spaces, tackle the garage or basement (12–20 hours). Like in *Star Trek*, this is the final frontier, the capstone project. Either the basement or the garage will likely be the biggest project and will take multiple sessions. You've already transformed your home and built up the stamina. The decision-making skills are there. This will mark the end goal of decluttering your home.

Can the sequence be adjusted? Of course. If your bedroom is a mess and affecting your sleep, then maybe move it up to third rather

than fifth. Potentially, your garage is somewhat tame, and the home office is a disaster. Adjust accordingly.

One more thing worth knowing: the chapters in this book aren't laid out in the exact order suggested above—they're organized to build your decision-making skills progressively, room type by room type. So don't worry about reading or working straight through from Chapter 3 to Chapter 13. Feel free to jump to whichever chapter matches your next room, in whatever order makes sense for your home and your energy that week.

The principle is still relevant regardless of the order. Start with moderate challenges, build momentum with visible wins, alternate between easy and hard projects, and save the biggest projects for when you've developed the skills.

A critical piece of sequencing is to finish the space or the room completely before moving on. Don't, for example, start decluttering the living room and advance to the kitchen without finishing the living room. This will result in a house in chaos because you don't know what mess to focus on.

When a room is decluttered, organize it and put systems in place. Then celebrate the win with a photo. Spend a few days enjoying the clear space. Let your brain process the feeling of completion, then move to the next space.

The approach outlined here gives you a series of victories instead of a war. Each space or room is a small battle that, when completed, is a win. Confidence builds with each win, making the next battle easier. By the time you tackle the basement or garage, you'll be a machine and will have made what seemed impossible manageable.

Step 4: Gather Supplies (But Don't Shop Prematurely!)

Here, we give a warning and say something to be emphatic and abundantly clear, as this is a common and costly mistake: DO

NOT BUY ORGANIZATIONAL PRODUCTS BEFORE YOU DECLUTTER.

Don't buy anything until you know exactly what you need. If there's a sale, even if there are nice baskets, don't buy them until you declutter and are ready to organize. This trap is so common. You might think, "I'm going to get organized, so I need storage bins, drawer dividers, closet dividers, baskets, and other things." After this, a few hundred dollars are spent. When the decluttering process finishes, you notice that you have much less stuff. The new organizational products are unused and add to the clutter themselves. This is somewhat ironic.

Very simply put, here is the rule: declutter first, organize second. Logically, you have no idea what storage solution you need until you know which items remain. You don't know what systems you want because you don't know what you're storing. After you've edited down the things that need to be stored, it's time to buy those items that serve your needs.

For the decluttering process itself, you only need the following:

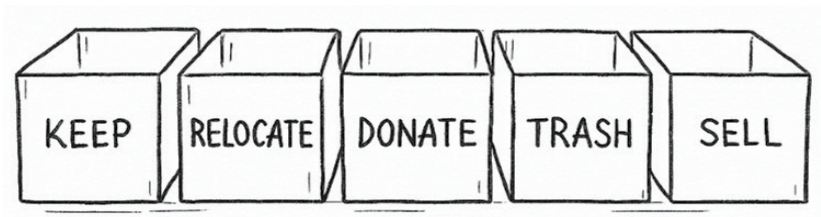
- **Large boxes or bins for sorting.** You can use anything you already have in the home to serve the purpose; these can be temporary items. Both cardboard boxes and laundry baskets work great. If you have four to five containers to set up the sorting station, that's plenty. (More to come below.)
- **Trash bags.** Gather regular and heavy-duty trash bags. You may have a concept of how much trash you'll identify, but you'll fill more bags than you expect. Those heavy trash bags will prevent the embarrassment of having something break open while being hauled to the curb or the trash.
- **Labels and markers.** These are to label the containers into categories, which we'll talk about later. You don't need anything fancy. A permanent marker with masking tape will be fine to create clear functional labels.

- **Cleaning supplies.** As you begin to declutter, you're going to reveal surfaces that have not been cleaned. As you move things off the table, clean it. Have some basic cleaning supplies on hand: all-purpose cleaner, soap and water, a rag or cloth, maybe a vacuum. These should be the normal cleaning supplies you commonly use, nothing special.

This is the list. Take note that there are no organizing bins. Resist buying more. Avoid this marketing trap. When you finish, you'll find you need fewer organizational supplies than you think.

Step 5: Set Up Your Sorting Station

Implementing the Five Container System will keep your current project moving forward without creating more chaos. If you don't use this system, you'll likely end up with piles of stuff everywhere with no clear path to process the items. This might cause you to abandon the decluttering ship as you become overwhelmed.



Here are the five containers that need to be labeled clearly:

- **Container One: Keep.** This container is for items you want to keep that belong in the current space or room being decluttered. These items just need to be organized or put away post-decluttering.

- **Container Two: Relocate.** This container is for items that you want to keep but belong somewhere other than the current space being decluttered, such as that storybook that ended up in the kitchen. They must be relocated.
- **Container Three: Donate.** This container is for items that are donation-worthy. They are gently used, decent, and functional and have some life to give someone else. Most of the decluttered items will end up in this bucket.
- **Container Four: Trash.** This is for trash—broken items, expired items, or things that are unusable. Items that are broken or have missing parts can't be donated. Don't burden others with garbage; just send those items to the trash.
- **Container Five: Monetary Recovery.** This is for high-value items that you want to sell rather than donate. The key is that these items need to be worth enough time to justify the effort of selling them. There should be a high bar of entry for this container.

Let's focus on the fifth container a bit more. A lot of people often get stuck on this point. You must realize that selling takes time and effort. In fact, some people do this as their job! Selling items involves taking good photographs, writing descriptions, listing them on a platform, pricing, communicating with buyers, and maybe shipping or arranging for pickup/drop-off. This represents a lot of time, effort, and coordination.

So, the real question is, what amount of money makes the time investment worthwhile? If you have a blender that you paid \$40 for five years ago and you might be able to sell it for \$10, is it worthwhile? The answer would be no; the time you would spend is less than minimum wage. On the other hand, if you have a designer handbag that might sell for several hundred dollars, then this could be a good trade.

You need to set a threshold of what you think the item can be sold for. The mental overhead of managing items for sale and the space they take up as they're waiting to be sold is not worth it for low-value items.

Also, you need to set a timeline for selling the item— maybe thirty days. You don't want the garage to become a consignment store. At this point, you're trying to declutter, not create a side hustle. You don't want to be sidetracked from decluttering into a side business.

Now, here's the rule that makes this entire system work: **full containers must be processed within one to two days.**

This is non-negotiable. This is the rule that separates people who finish from people who stall out. If your Donate container is full, it gets dropped off at a donation center within two days maximum. If your Trash container is full, it goes to the curb on trash day. If your Relocate container is full, spend twenty minutes walking around your house putting those items in their proper homes.

Why is this timing so important? Because if you let containers pile up, you create decision paralysis. You start looking at the mountain of stuff waiting to be processed and get overwhelmed. The momentum dies. Worse, you might start second-guessing your decisions. You'll go through the donate pile and pull things back out. You'll convince yourself you need that thing after all. You'll stall the whole process and end up right back where you started.

Process as you go. Keep things flowing out of your home. You want to keep the momentum alive and prevent a backlog. There's a psychological benefit to seeing the stuff move through the pipeline and making progress. When you drop off that first load of donations, you'll feel accomplished. You'll feel lighter. You'll want to keep going.

Another practical tip is to put the donation bags in the car. As you run errands, those bags are at hand to be dropped off. Make the

process as easy as possible to get items out of your house. The less friction in the process, the more likely you are to follow through.

Set up your command center—the sorting station with your five containers—somewhere near the room you’re working on, but not in the middle of your main living space. If you’re working on the kitchen, maybe set it up in the garage or on the back porch if the weather permits. If you’re working on a bedroom, maybe in the hallway. You want it close enough to be convenient (you don’t want to be walking up and down stairs fifty times), but not so central that it’s in everyone’s way or creating visual chaos in a space you’ve already cleared.

Keep this sorting station operational and active throughout your entire project. You’ll move it as you move from room to room, but the system itself remains consistent. This consistency eliminates decision-making; you don’t have to reinvent the process for each space. You just work on the system. Touch an item, make a decision, put it in the appropriate container. Touch the next item, make a decision, put it in the appropriate container. The system creates a rhythm that makes the work almost meditative once you get into the flow.

Step 6: Deploy the Core Decision Systems

The heart of the problem is to decide what stays and what goes. You need a decision framework that can get through the emotional noise and allow you to make consistent choices. If you don’t have a framework, each item will paralyze you with indecision, creating mental and emotional exhaustion.

To solve this problem, we have the **Three-Question Clutter Killer**. For each item you lay your hands on, ask yourself these three questions.

THREE-QUESTION CLUTTER KILLER

Question One: Do I use this? 	Question Two: Does it bring me genuine joy or hold significant sentimental value? 	Question Three: If I didn't own this already, would I buy it again today? 
Decision Rule: If you answer NO to all three questions, let it go. If at least one question was a YES, then keep it for now.		

Question One: Do I use this?

This question is about today and now. It's not "might I use this someday" or "could I use this if the circumstances were different" or "I used this once three years ago." This question is simple: Do I use this item now in my life today?

Be honest. If you haven't used the item in the past year, you don't use it. There will be some exceptions, like seasonal items. Using items in the past is not the same as using them now. The possibility of using items in the future is not the same as using them now.

Question Two: Does it bring me genuine joy or hold significant sentimental value?

In this question, there are two key items: "genuine joy" and "significant sentimental value." Genuine joy is when you hold or see

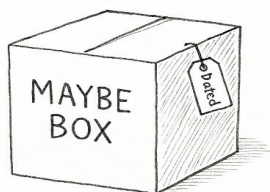
an item and your heart lifts, you feel happy, or you break into a smile. Sentimental items have a high bar attached to them. They refer to items that are truly meaningful. It is probably not that sweater you wore once to dinner; that does not make it sentimentally valuable.

Question Three: If I didn't own this already, would I buy it again today?

This question neutralizes the sunk cost fallacy by forcing you to evaluate the item based on its current value to you. The monetary cost of the item is removed, as well as the circumstances under which it was purchased. If you could acquire the item now, even for free, would you take it and bring it home? Are you willing to spend money on this item? Do you want to make physical room for it now?

If you answer no, then you have what you need to know. It's not useful to you, and it's just taking up space. If you answered all the questions negatively for the item, it should be released. If at least one question is answered positively, the item stays for the present. Here, we aren't looking for perfection but a reduction in clutter.

Sometimes you might stall out or hesitate over an item. Maybe it will be used again, or you're not sure if it has sentimental value. You don't want to waste time overthinking, so put this in the **Maybe Box**.



The Maybe Box must be for those genuinely undecided items. It should not be more than 10-20 percent of the items being evaluated.